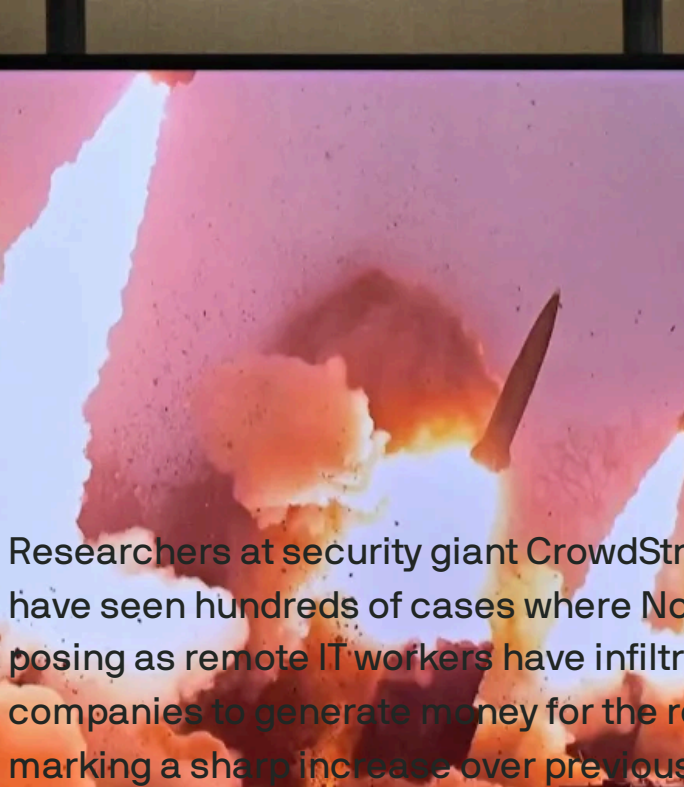




SECURITY



North Korean spies posing as remote workers have infiltrated hundreds of companies, says CrowdStrike



Researchers at security giant CrowdStrike say they have seen hundreds of cases where North Koreans posing as remote IT workers have infiltrated companies to generate money for the regime, marking a sharp increase over previous years.

Per [CrowdStrike's latest threat hunting report](#), the company has identified more than 320 incidents over the past 12 months, up from 120 in the year earlier, in which North Koreans gained fraudulent employment at Western companies working remotely as developers.

The scheme relies on North Koreans using false identities, resumes, and work histories to gain employment and earn money for the regime, as well as allowing access for the workers to steal data from the companies they work for and later extort them. The aim is to generate funds for North Korea's sanctioned nuclear weapons program, which has so far made [billions of dollars for the regime](#) to date.

It's not known exactly how many North Korean IT workers are currently working for unknowing U.S. companies, but some have estimated the number to be in the thousands.

According to CrowdStrike, the North Korean IT workers, which the company calls “Famous Chollima” using its naming scheme of hacking groups, rely on generative AI and other AI-powered

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tools to draft resumes and modify or “deepfake” their appearance during remote interviews.

While [the scheme is not new](#), North Koreans are increasingly succeeding at getting jobs, despite sanctions preventing U.S. companies from hiring North Korean workers.

CrowdStrike said in its report that one of the ways to prevent hiring sanctioned workers is by implementing better identity verification processes during the hiring phase. TechCrunch has anecdotally heard of some crypto-focused companies asking prospective employees to say critical things about North Korea’s leader, Kim Jong Un, in an effort to weed out potential spies. The would-be North Korean employees are often highly monitored and surveilled, making any such request impossible and likely outing the fraudulent worker.

Over the past year, the U.S. Department of Justice has sought to disrupt these operations by going after the U.S.-based facilitators who help [run and operate the scheme](#) for their North Korean bosses. These operations have included [targeting the individuals who run “laptop farm” operations](#), which include racks of open laptops used by the North Koreans to remotely do their work as if they were physically located in the United States.

Prosecutors said [in a June indictment](#) that one North Korean operation stole the identities of 80 individuals in the U.S. between 2021 and 2024 to get remote work at more than 100 U.S. companies.

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SECURITY

Data breach at French telecom giant Bouygues affects millions of customers

Zack Whittaker — 6:45 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

Bouygues Telecom, the third-largest phone carrier in France, has confirmed a cyberattack and data

breach affecting millions of its customers.

In [a statement posted to its website](#), the telecommunications giant said the hack allowed the intruders to access the personal information on 6.4 million customer accounts. Bouygues said it detected the cyberattack on August 4, but did not give a time frame for when the breach was remediated.

In [a separate page](#) dedicated to victims of the cyberattack, Bouygues said the stolen data includes customers' contact information and contractual data, their civil status (or company data if the subscriber is a professional), as well as IBANs, or international bank account numbers.

Bouygues said it has about 26.9 million mobile customers.

The cyberattack has been reported to France's data protection agency, CNIL.

At the time of publication, Bouygues' [web page](#) about the cyberattack contained a hidden "noindex" tag in its source code, which instructs search engines to ignore the page, making it difficult for anyone searching the web to find the page.

A spokesperson for Bouygues did not immediately respond to a request for comment asking for details about the cyberattack, or explain why the page was hidden from search engines.

News of the breach comes soon after [a cyberattack at French telecom giant Orange](#), the country's largest phone carrier and one of the largest telecommunication companies in the world. On July 29, Orange told customers to expect disruption as it moved to "isolate potentially affected

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TeaOnHer, a rival Tea app for men, is leaking users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling, Zack Whittaker

12:40 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

TeaOnHer, an app designed for men to share photos and information about women they have supposedly dated, has exposed users' personal information, including government IDs and selfies, TechCrunch can confirm.

The app, which launched on the Apple App Store earlier this week, is a response to another viral app Tea that allows women to post about the men they date. Tea is advertised as a women's safety app with more than 6 million users that is similar to "[Are we dating the same guy?](#)" Facebook networks. However, the app is controversial, since many of the claims that women post cannot be verified.

The backlash surrounding Tea escalated last week, after 404 Media reported 4chan users retaliated by [discovering a publicly exposed database](#) belonging to the app, which [revealed](#) over 72,000 images, including thousands of selfies and photo IDs submitted for account verification. A [subsequent hack](#) exposed more than 1 million private messages sent over the app, prompting the app to [disable](#) its messaging feature.

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TeaOnHer, a rival Tea app for men, is leaking users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling,

TeaOnHer, which is now ranked No. 2 among Lifestyle apps on iOS, appears to be a direct rebuttal to the Tea app, even copying the language from Tea's App Store description in its own listing.

But like the app it sought to emulate, TeaOnHer contains security flaws of its own.

TechCrunch has found at least one security flaw that allows anyone access to data belonging to TeaOnHer app users, including their usernames and associated email addresses, as well as driver's licenses and selfies that users uploaded to TeaOnHer. Images of these driver's licenses are publicly accessible web addresses, allowing anyone with the links to access them using their web browser.

In one case, TechCrunch saw a list of posts shared on TeaOnHer appended with each user's email address, display name, and self-reported location.

TechCrunch is withholding some of the details of the bugs so as to not help malicious actors access anyone's data. The app's maker did not respond to emails from TechCrunch asking who we can report the flaws to. As such, TechCrunch is publishing this report with limited details of the issue, given the app's current popularity and the risk faced with using the app.

TeaOnHer was uploaded to the iOS App Store by a developer named Newville Media Corporation. According to LinkedIn, the founder and CEO of this company is Xavier Lampkin.

TechCrunch identified at least one TeaOnHer record associated with Lampkin's own data.

The security lapse will likely affect any user who signed up or shared identity documents with the app. The bug also exposes the number of users the

Zack Whittaker

- 21 hours ago

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Citizen Lab director warns cyber industry about US authoritarian descent

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

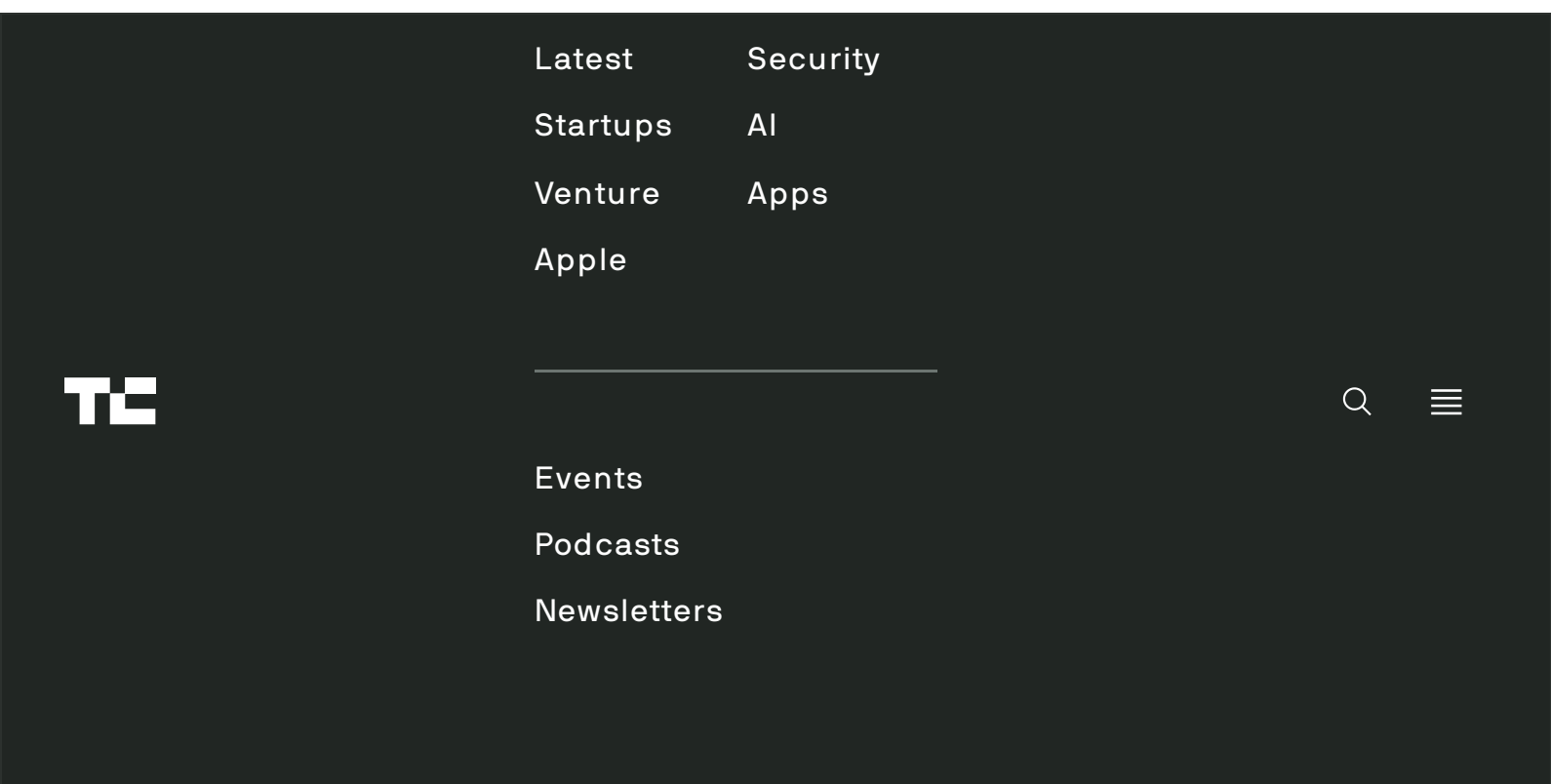
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TeaOnHer app has, which is about 53,000 users at the time of publication.

TechCrunch also identified a potential second security issue, in which an email address and plaintext password belonging to the app’s creator, Lampkin, was left exposed on the server. The credentials appear to grant access to the app’s “admin” panel. TechCrunch did not use the credentials, as doing so would be unlawful, but highlights the risks of inadvertently leaving admin credentials exposed to the web.

Along with its security flaws, the content portrayed within TeaOnHer is troubling in itself. While the app requests IDs and selfies from its users to verify their identities — a process that is not automatic — users can access a “guest” view of the app without signing in.



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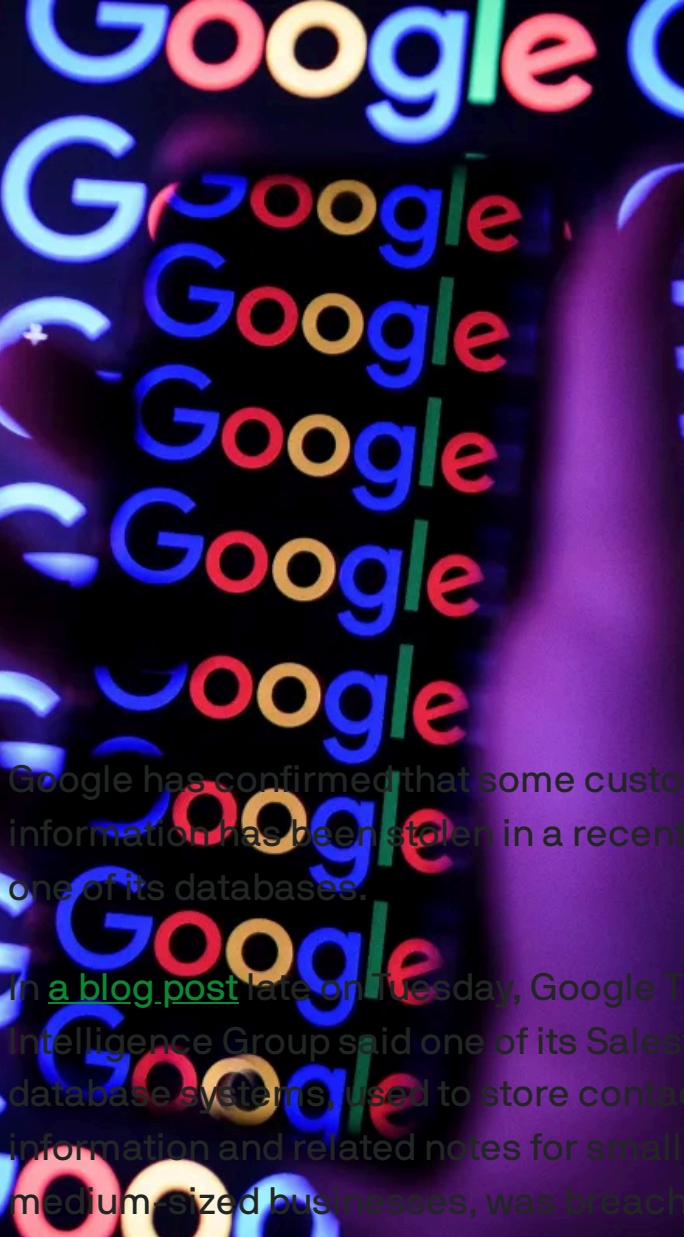
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SECURITY



Google says hackers stole its customers' data



by breaching its Salesforce database

Zack Whittaker — 5:05 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Google has confirmed that some customers' information has been stolen in a recent breach of one of its databases.

In a [blog post](#) late on Tuesday, Google Threat Intelligence Group said one of its Salesforce database systems, used to store contact information and related notes for small and medium-sized businesses, was breached by a hacking group popularly known as ShinyHunters, formally designated as UNC6040.

IMAGE CREDITS: LEON NEAL / GETTY IMAGES

“The data retrieved by the threat actor was confined to basic and largely publicly available business information, such as business names and contact details,” the company said.

Google did not disclose how many customers are affected, and Google spokesperson Mark Karayan declined to comment beyond the company's blog post. It's not clear if the company has received any communication, such as a ransom demand.

ShinyHunters is known for targeting big companies and their cloud-based databases.

This is the latest in a series of breaches targeting Salesforce cloud systems, after recent thefts of

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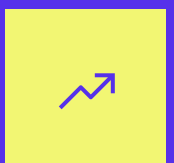
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[customer data from Cisco](#) and [airline giant Qantas](#), [retail giant Pandora](#), among others, as [reported by Bleeping Computer](#). According to Google's blog post, the ShinyHunters group relies on voice phishing techniques to trick company employees into granting them access to their cloud-based Salesforce databases.

Google said the ShinyHunters group is likely preparing a data leak site, which some ransomware gangs use to publish stolen data to [extort their corporate victims](#) into paying a ransom. The group is said to have overlaps with other groups, [including The Com](#), a known collective of cybercriminals who use hacking, extortion, and sometimes threats of violence to break into networks.

Do you know more about the Google data breach? Have you been notified by Google? Securely contact this reporter via encrypted message at [zackwhittaker.1337](#) on Signal.

Updated with response from Google.

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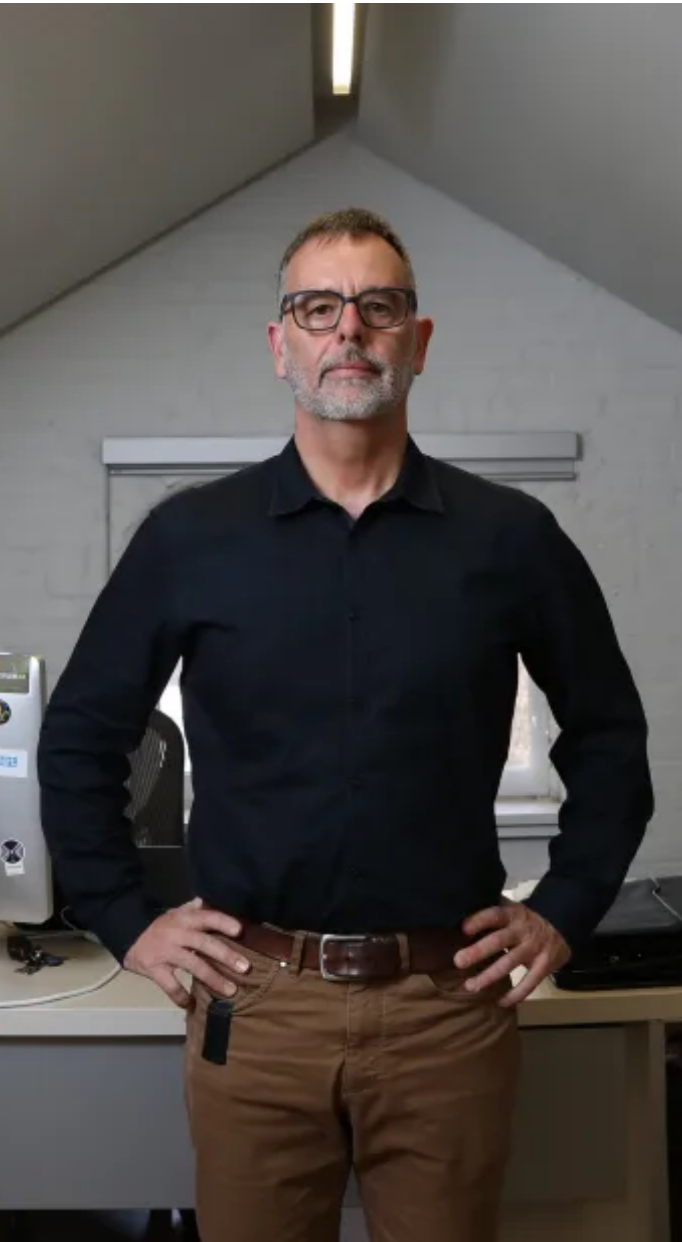
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SECURITY

Citizen Lab director warns cyber industry about US authoritarian descent

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

8:01 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:

RENE JOHNSTON/TORONTO STAR / GETTY IMAGES

Ron Deibert, the director of Citizen Lab, one of the most prominent organizations investigating government spyware abuses, is sounding the alarm to the cybersecurity community and asking them to step up and join the fight against authoritarianism.

On Wednesday, Deibert [will deliver a keynote](#) at the Black Hat cybersecurity conference in Las Vegas, one of the largest gatherings of information security professionals of the year.

Ahead of his talk, Deibert told TechCrunch that he plans to speak about what he describes as a “descent into a kind of fusion of tech and fascism,” and the role that the Big Tech platforms are playing, and “propelling forward a really frightening type of collective insecurity that isn’t typically addressed by this crowd, this community, as a cybersecurity problem.”

Deibert described the recent political events in the United States as a “dramatic descent into authoritarianism,” but one that the cybersecurity community can help defend against.

“I think alarm bells need to be rung for this community that, at the very least, they should be aware of what’s going on and hopefully they can not contribute to it, if not help reverse it,” Deibert told TechCrunch.

Historically, at least in the United States, the cybersecurity industry has put politics — to a certain extent — to the side. More recently, however, politics has fully entered the world of cybersecurity.

Earlier this year, President Donald Trump [ordered an investigation into former CISA director Chris Krebs](#), who had publicly rebuffed Trump’s false claims about election fraud by declaring the 2020 election secure. Trump later [fired Krebs by tweet](#).

The investigation ordered by Trump months after his 2024 reelection forced Krebs to [step down from SentinelOne and vow to fight back](#).

In response, Jen Easterly, another former CISA director and Krebs’ successor, [called on the cybersecurity community to get involved](#) and speak out.

“If we stay silent when experienced, mission-driven leaders are sidelined or sanctioned, we risk something greater than discomfort; we risk diminishing the very institutions we are here to protect,” Easterly wrote in a post on LinkedIn.

Easterly was herself [a victim of political pressure](#) from the Trump administration when her offer to join West Point was rescinded in late July.

Deibert, who this year [published his new book](#), “Chasing Shadows: Cyber Espionage, Subversion, and the Global Fight for Democracy,” is echoing the same message as Easterly.

“I think that there comes a point at which you have to recognize that the landscape is changing around you, and the security problems you set out for yourselves are maybe trivial in light of the broader context and the insecurities that are being propelled forward in the absence of proper checks and balances and oversight, which are deteriorating,” said Deibert.

Deibert is also concerned that big companies like Meta, Google, and Apple could take a step back in their efforts to fight against government spyware — [sometimes referred](#) to as “commercial” or “mercenary” spyware — by gutting their threat intelligence teams.

These threat intelligence teams are dedicated groups of security researchers that track

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government hackers, both those working inside government agencies, such as China's Ministry of State Security or Russia's intelligence agencies FSB and GRU, and companies such as NSO Group or Paragon.

These are the same teams that are responsible for detecting hacks against their own users, such as when [WhatsApp caught NSO Group](#) hacking more than 1,400 of its users in 2019, or when Apple caught hackers using government spyware to target its customers and [notified the victims](#) of the [attacks](#).

Deibert believes there is a “huge market failure when it comes to cybersecurity for global civil society,” a part of the population that generally cannot afford to get help from big security companies that typically serve governments and corporate clients. “This market failure is going to get more acute as supporting institutions evaporate and attacks on civil society amplify,” he said.

“Whatever they can do to contribute to offset this market failure (e.g., pro bono work) will be essential to the future of liberal democracy worldwide,” he said.

Deibert is concerned that these threat intelligence teams could be cut or at least reduced, given that the same companies have cut their moderation and safety teams.

He told TechCrunch that threat intelligence teams, like the ones at Meta, are doing “amazing work,” in part by staying siloed and separate from the commercial arms of their wider organizations.

“But the question is how long will that last?” said Deibert.

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